IIMB
तेजस्वि नावधीतमस्तु

CSITM
Centre for Software and Information Technology Management

In Partnership with PayU

FOLLOW THE MONEY

Innovation Challenge

Open to college students from all disciplines

26 November 2026 | IIM Bangalore



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About

Every day, fraudsters find new ways to slip past the systems built to stop them. As digital payments become faster and easier, the vulnerabilities behind seemingly ordinary transactions become harder to spot. What if the next solution came from you?

The Follow the Money: Innovation Challenge, organised by CSITM, IIM Bangalore, in partnership with PayU, invites students from diverse disciplines to tackle real-world challenges in digital payment security and financial fraud. Participants are encouraged to think beyond conventional approaches and develop innovative, practical solutions that bridge technology, business, policy and human behaviour.

The challenge unfolds across two rounds, taking teams from initial idea submissions to a final showcase. Participants develop and refine their solutions, demonstrating originality, feasibility and potential for real-world impact. Finalist teams present their ideas at IIM Bangalore, where solutions are evaluated on problem understanding, innovation, practical feasibility, and clarity of execution.

What's in it for you?

- Work on a real fraud problem shaped by the challenges faced by the payments industry.
- Present your solution at IIM Bangalore before a jury of industry experts and faculty.
- Gain insights into your solution's practicality, potential impact and scalability.
- Compete for a ₹70,000 prize pool.
- Finalists can take home goodies, including T-shirts and badges, while participants get certificates from IIMB.
- Gain insights into financial cybercrime through a panel discussion featuring leaders from law enforcement, payments and cybersecurity, with opportunities for further industry engagement.
- Connect with fellow innovators, industry professionals and experts across disciplines.



The Problem Statement

The Bakery That Takes Bets

The Challenge

Every day, payment providers onboard thousands of businesses, enabling them to accept digital payments from customers across the country. From small neighbourhood shops to online service providers, these businesses rely on payment infrastructure to operate, grow and reach new customers.

However, not every business uses this infrastructure for the purpose it claims to serve. Some merchants may register with legitimate business details but subsequently use their payment accounts to collect money for prohibited activities, including illegal betting. Their registration documents may be authentic, and their transactions may appear legitimate when examined individually.

For a payment provider, this creates a difficult challenge. How do you determine whether a merchant is operating legitimately when neither its documents nor its individual transactions necessarily reveal the full picture?

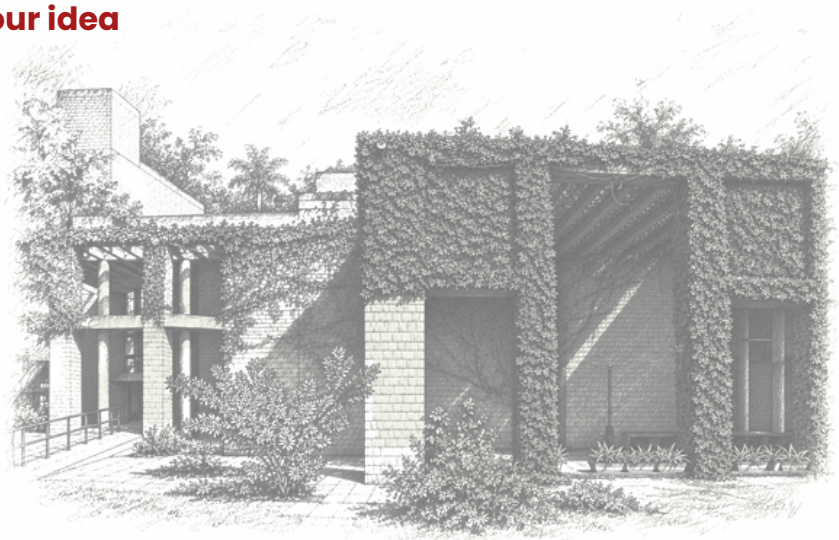
Identifying suspicious activity is only part of the problem. Businesses evolve, customer behaviour changes, and seasonal demand can significantly alter transaction patterns. Overly aggressive controls risk disrupting genuine businesses, while insufficient scrutiny can allow fraudulent activity to continue undetected.

Payment providers must therefore find ways to assess merchant legitimacy beyond initial registration, recognise when actual business activity no longer aligns with declared business information, and respond proportionately to potential risks.

Your Challenge

How might a payment provider identify and address merchants whose actual activities may differ from their declared business purpose, while protecting legitimate businesses from unnecessary scrutiny, disruption or penalties?

Solutions can be technical, business, policy-driven, behavioural, or a mix. Choose the format that fits your idea



Challenge Structure

01

Online Submission

Round 1

Submit a presentation of up to 8 slides, and a video of up to 2 minutes. The top teams are selected for the on-campus finale.

Presentation:
Your presentation deck should communicate the following aspects of your proposed solution:

- Explain your idea, its core approach and what makes it distinctive.
- Outline how your solution operates, including its workflow, key components and architecture, where applicable.
- Highlight where and how your solution addresses fraudulent activity.
- Explain how the solution could work in practice, including relevant technologies, processes, resources or partnerships.
- Describe the expected outcomes, how success could be measured and the potential for real-world adoption.

Video Submission:

- Show us your idea in action! Get creative with how you communicate your solution. You could create a short film, mock advertisement, scenario-based demonstration, animation, storytelling piece or product pitch. **Teams with a technical solutions must also build and demonstrate a working prototype**. Focus on making your video original, engaging, understandable and compelling.

02

On-Campus Finale

Round 2

Shortlisted teams present their solutions at a live exhibition at IIM Bangalore. Teams can showcase their ideas through posters, working prototypes (where applicable), models, demonstrations or other creative visual formats. **Displaying a working prototype is mandatory for technical solutions**. Judges visit each team's stall to evaluate the solutions, interact with participants and assess their ideas. Winners are recognised at the event.

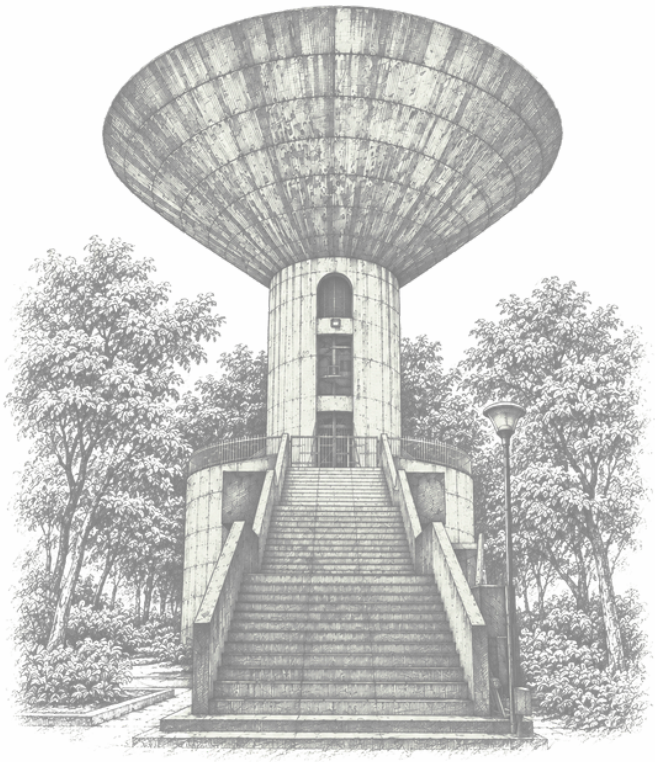
Evaluation

Round 1

Criterion	Weight	What is Evaluated
Problem Understanding	15%	Understanding of the challenge and relevance of the solution.
Innovation & Originality	25%	Novelty and creativity of the approach.
Solution Design & Approach	20%	Clarity of the solution, workflow and intervention points.
Feasibility & Real-World Impact	25%	Practicality, effectiveness, scalability & fraud prevention impact.
Presentation & Communication	15%	Clarity, creativity and effectiveness of the PPT and video.

Evaluation Notes

- Both the PPT and video submissions will be evaluated against the criteria listed above.
- The evaluation panel's decision will be final.



Round 2

Criterion	Weight	What Is Evaluated?
Demonstration & Proof of Concept	25%	How convincingly the solution is demonstrated.
Technical & Operational Soundness	15%	Soundness of approach and handling of constraints.
Practical Feasibility	15%	Practicality of real-world implementation.
Innovation & Differentiation	25%	Originality and differentiation from existing solutions.
Judge Engagement & Communication	10%	Clarity of communication and engagement.
Q&A & Critical Thinking	10%	Ability to defend decisions and address limitations.

Evaluation Notes

- Teams will present their solutions at exhibition stalls featuring posters and supporting materials.
- Judges will visit each stall to evaluate the solution and interact with the team.
- All team members should be prepared to explain and defend their proposed solution.
- The evaluation panel's decision will be final.



General Rules

Eligibility

- Open to college students from any discipline at recognised institutions across India
- Team size: 1-4 members
- Cross-college teams are allowed.
- Each student may be part of only one team.

How to Participate

- **STEP 1:** Register on Unstop as a team of 1–4 members to participate in the Follow the Money: Innovation Challenge.

- **STEP 2:** Submit your presentation deck as a PDF, and a video of up to 2 minutes showcasing your proposed solution. Upload both files to a Google Drive folder and share the folder link with view access enabled. Ensure that all files are accessible to the organisers. Shortlisted teams will be notified about the next round.

- **STEP 3:** Shortlisted teams will present their solutions at an exhibition at IIM Bangalore on November 26, 2026. Teams will showcase their ideas through posters, working prototypes (where applicable), demonstrations or other creative formats before a jury of industry experts and faculty. Winners will be recognised at the event.

Use of AI

- While use of AI tools is allowed, AI should support your thinking, not replace it. All submissions are judged on originality, so solutions that rely on generic, AI-generated ideas without your own insight, judgment and contribution will score lower. Be prepared to explain your choices and defend your solution in front of the jury.

Awards

- The challenge, organised by CSITM, IIM Bangalore, in partnership with PayU, features a prize pool of ₹70,000, with ₹40,000 for the first-place team, ₹20,000 for the second-place team and ₹10,000 for the third-place team. All participants will receive certificates from IIM Bangalore, while finalists attending the on-campus exhibition will receive goodies, including T-shirts and badges. Finalists will also have the opportunity to attend the panel discussion featuring leaders from law enforcement, payments and cybersecurity, with opportunities for further industry engagement.